

THE HISTORY OF GDYNIA

From a Quiet Fishing Village to a Modernist Seaport

1. EARLY ORIGINS (13TH - 19TH CENTURY)

For most of its existence, Gdynia was merely a small, sleepy fishing and farming village on the Baltic coast. The first historical mention of the settlement dates back to 1253. For centuries, it was owned by the Cistercian order and later by various noble families. In the late 19th century, while under Prussian rule, Gdynia began to attract its first summer vacationers, gradually developing a modest reputation as a seaside resort town.

2. A STRATEGIC NECESSITY (1920)

The turning point in Gdynia's history came after World War I. When Poland regained its independence in 1918, it was granted a tiny stretch of coastline (the "Polish Corridor"), but it lacked a major seaport. Neighboring Gdansk was established as a Free City, leaving Poland without secure, sovereign access to international maritime trade routes. The Polish government realized that building a brand new, fully Polish port from scratch was a matter of national survival.

3. THE PORT CONSTRUCTION BOOM (1920S - 1930S)

In 1922, the Polish parliament officially authorized the construction of the Port of Gdynia. Under the visionary leadership of Minister of Industry and Trade Eugeniusz Kwiatkowski, the project became a massive national effort. Engineers and workers flocked from all over Poland. Within an incredibly short span of a decade, Gdynia transformed from a village of 1,000 residents into a bustling city of over 100,000. By 1938, it had become the largest and most modern seaport on the Baltic Sea.

4. THE "WHITE CITY" AND MODERNIST ARCHITECTURE

Because Gdynia was built essentially from the ground up during the 1920s and 1930s, its architecture reflects the dominant style of the era: Modernism. The city became known as the "White City" due to its bright, sleek buildings designed with functionalist principles. Many structures featured maritime motifs, such as rounded balconies resembling ship decks, porthole windows, and clean, aerodynamic lines.

5. WORLD WAR II (1939 - 1945)

Gdynia was occupied by Nazi Germany in September 1939. The city was forcefully renamed "Gotenhafen," and the majority of its Polish inhabitants were brutally expelled or sent to concentration camps, replaced by German settlers. The port was converted into a vital German naval base, which consequently made it a major target for intense Allied bombing raids. Despite heavy damage to the port infrastructure, the city's residential center largely survived the war.

6. POST-WAR REBUILDING AND THE DECEMBER 1970 PROTESTS

Following the war, Gdynia was returned to Poland, and its original residents began to return. The port and shipyards were quickly rebuilt and expanded under the communist regime. However, in December 1970, Gdynia became the site of a tragic and historic event. Shipyard workers protesting sudden food price increases were violently fired upon by the communist military and police near the local train station. The "Black Thursday" massacre became a deep scar in the city's history and a precursor to the later Solidarity movement.

7. THE MODERN METROPOLIS

Today, Gdynia is a thriving, dynamic city that forms the northern tip of the Tricity metropolitan area (alongside Gdansk and Sopot). It has successfully transitioned its economy from a strict reliance on heavy maritime industry to modern services, technology, and culture. Consistently ranking as one of the best cities to live in Poland, Gdynia proudly embraces its unique interwar history, maritime heritage, and modernist architectural legacy.